



OFF-SIDE

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THE FINE PRINT OF SPORT

In every game's **rulebook** lies a quiet theatre of absurdities — clauses that confuse, amuse, and occasionally decide history.

Sport showcases amazing feats, but often it is the footnotes — the arcane appendices of rulebooks — that steal the show. In cricket's 1981 underarm incident, Australian captain Greg Chappell asked his brother Trevor to roll the final ball, denying New Zealand the chance to hit a six. Legal at the time, it caused such outrage that the ICC soon banned underarm bowling.

At the 2025 Ryder Cup at Bethpage Black, Europe's Viktor Hovland withdrew from his singles match with a neck injury. The tournament's 'Envelope Rule' was invoked for just the third time since 1979. The rule allows each captain to secretly name one player who must sit out if an opponent falls ill or is injured. When Hovland withdrew, U.S. captain Keegan Bradley's sealed choice, Harris English, was benched, and the points were halved.

As Indians, we are still pained by Sachin Tendulkar's 1999 Adelaide LBW dismissal. Glenn McGrath's bouncer hit Tendulkar's shoulder as he ducked, yet umpire Daryl Harper raised his finger. Law 36.1.3 states: "the ball not having previously touched his/her bat, the striker intercepts the ball, either full-pitch or after pitching, with any part of his/her person." Any part being the operative phrase here, and McGrath, beneficiary of the law's largesse, later cheekily said: "Was it LBW? Should have been SBW – Shoulder Before Wicket."

The hat-fall rule in tennis is equally mischievous. It states that if a player's hat inadvertently falls off mid-rally, or a ball slips from a pocket, the point is replayed as it is deemed a "hindrance." The rule was invoked at the 2012 U.S.

Open semifinals against Andy Murray when Tomas Berdych protested that he had been distracted by his opponent's cap blowing off. Though chair umpire Pascal Maria ruled play was complete when the cap came off, Murray agreed to replay the point.

This strict rule enforcement saw Serena Williams being penalised the previous year when she shouted, "Come on!" a split second early and lost a point for verbal hindrance in her final against Samantha Stosur. Needless to say, Serena did not greet the ruling with Murray's grace.

Chess, too, can be theatrical in its strictness. Magnus Carlsen was disqualified from the 2024 World Rapid & Blitz Championships for wearing jeans. FIDE's dress code deemed denim "unsuitable," and when Carlsen refused to change, he was fined USD 200 and told to sit out.

Sport's odd rules persist elsewhere as well. In American football, the fair catch free kick rule resurfaced in December 2024 when the Los Angeles Chargers scored one — the first successful attempt since 1976 — against the Denver Broncos. After a fair catch, a team may take an uncontested field goal from the spot.

These rules, tucked into the margins of sporting history, remind us how thin the line is between order and overreach. The beauty of sport lies not only in the backhands and buzzer-beaters, but in its quiet absurdities — forgotten clauses that often surface to confuse, amuse, and humble.

If sport mirrors life, these are its fine print — rarely read, occasionally enforced, but always capable of ruining a perfect day.